

JUST DO IT.

Short-Form Content Strategy

What Drives Reach and Engagement on TikTok & YouTube Shorts

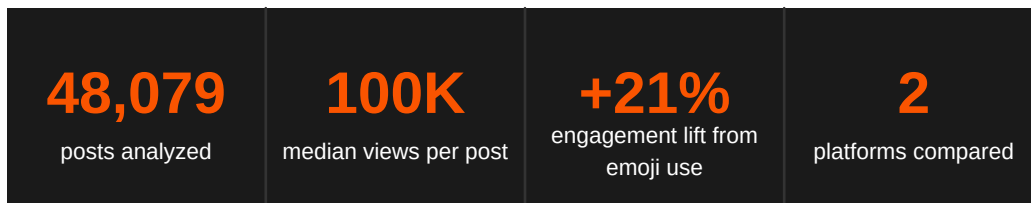
A business report on Nike's short-form video performance, based on analysis of 48,079 posts, prepared to inform content, creator, and scheduling strategy.

Executive Summary

Short-form video is a volume game with a few strong, controllable levers. We analyzed nearly 48,000 posts across TikTok and YouTube Shorts to find out what actually separates strong content from average content — and what Nike can influence versus what's largely out of our hands.

The clearest finding: **who posts matters more than what or when they post**. Creator track record is the single strongest signal of future reach we found — stronger than category, timing, platform, or content format combined. Scheduling and category choices still matter, but as fine-tuning, not as the primary lever.

We also tested whether reach can be predicted before a video is even posted. It largely can't — meaning Nike should stop trying to pre-screen for virality and instead build a system to detect and amplify winning content in its first hours online, when the real signal appears.



The Story in Three Findings

1. Creators carry the content, not the other way around

When we modeled what predicts a post landing in the top 15% for views, one factor stood out by a wide margin: the creator's own historical average views. It accounted for 25% of everything the model could explain — more than double the next closest factor (video duration). Category, platform, timing, and format together explained far less than creator history alone.

2. Timing and format help — but only at the margins

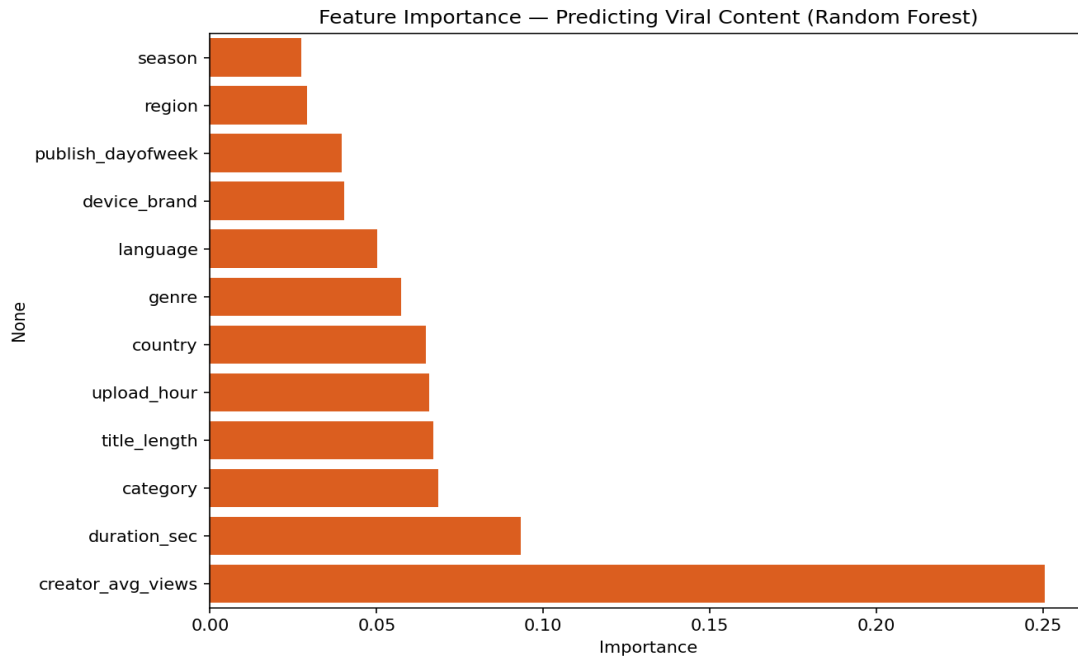
The best-performing posting windows outperform an average slot by only a few percentage points in engagement, not multiples. The same is true of category choice and video duration — real, measurable, but secondary effects. These are worth optimizing, but won't move the needle the way creator strategy will.

3. Virality can't be reliably predicted before a video is posted

We built a model to flag likely-viral content using only information available before publishing — category, duration, platform, timing, creator history, and similar attributes. It performed only marginally better than a coin flip (accuracy of predicting the viral/not-viral split). This tells us something important: virality is driven more by real-time audience reaction and platform distribution than by any static content brief. Trying to pre-approve content for 'viral potential' is not a reliable strategy with the signals available today.

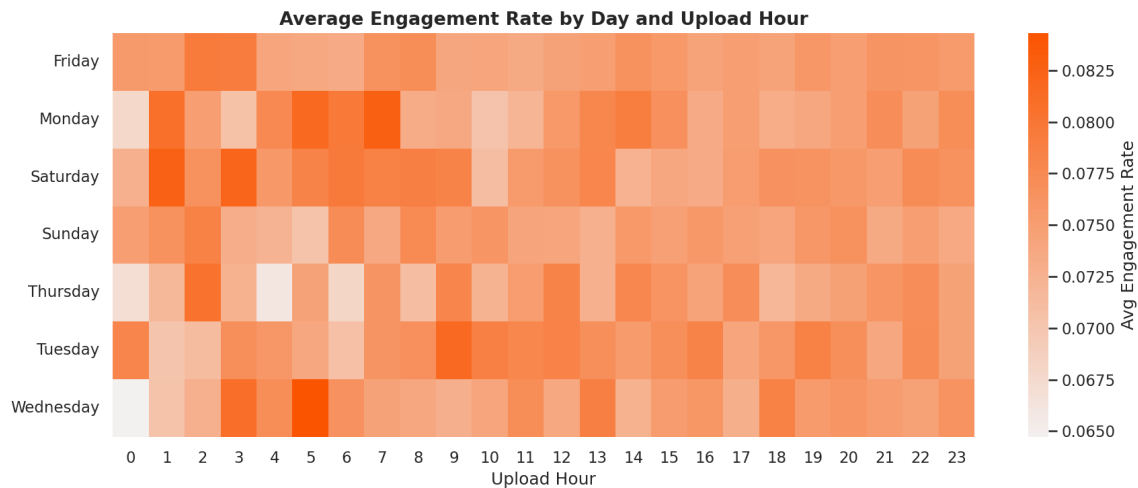
Supporting Evidence

Creator history is the dominant signal



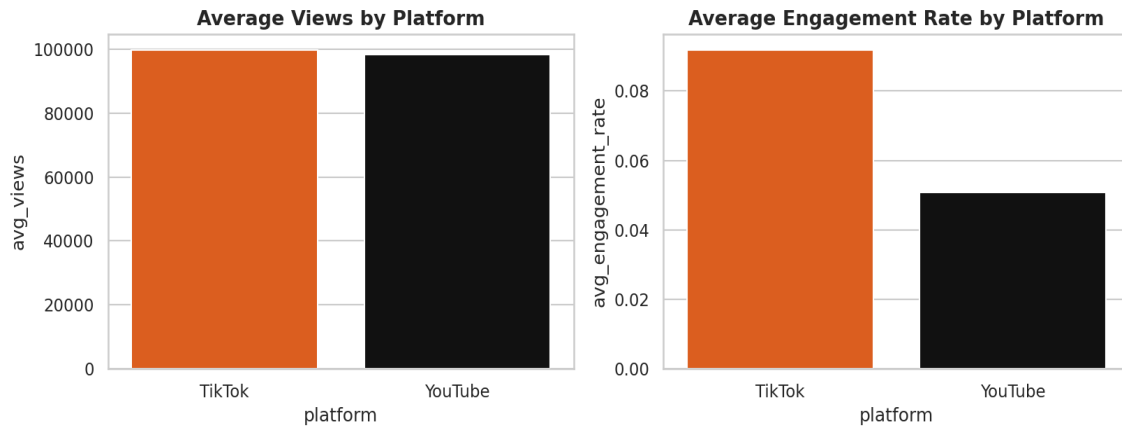
What actually predicts a top-performing post — creator history dwarfs every content or timing factor.

Best posting windows exist, but the gains are modest



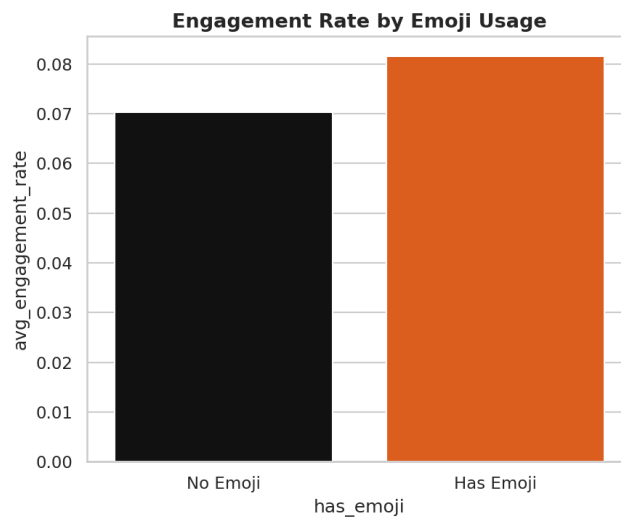
Engagement rate by publish day and hour — brighter cells post modestly better, not dramatically better.

Platform behaviour differs — treat them separately



TikTok and YouTube Shorts show different reach and engagement patterns — a shared content plan should still allow platform-specific execution.

Small creative details move engagement, even when views stay flat



Posts with emoji in the title see meaningfully higher engagement rate, despite near-identical average views.

Strategic Recommendations

Five moves, ordered by expected impact based on what the data actually supports.

1. Make creator selection the primary lever, not an afterthought

Since creator history is the strongest predictor of reach by a wide margin, shift budget and planning time toward building and retaining relationships with proven creators, while running a smaller, structured pipeline to test and graduate new ones. This is the single highest-leverage change available.

2. Replace pre-publication approval with a real-time amplification system

Because virality can't be reliably predicted before posting, stop trying to pick winners in advance. Instead, monitor engagement velocity in the first 1-2 hours after a post goes live, and have paid media ready to boost anything that's already showing early traction.

3. Use scheduling and category insights as tie-breakers, not strategy

Best-performing time slots and categories are real but modest advantages. Bake them into the content calendar as default choices, but don't over-invest planning time chasing the 'perfect' posting hour.

4. Optimize creative for completion, not just length or watch time

Longer videos hold attention longer in raw seconds, but are proportionally less likely to be watched to the end. Brief creators and editors to pace for completion rate, especially in the first few seconds.

5. Keep platform strategies distinct

TikTok and YouTube Shorts show different engagement behaviour. Continue tailoring content style, captions, and pacing separately for each platform rather than cross-posting identical cuts.

Bottom Line

Nike's short-form content performance is shaped far more by **who** is creating than by **what**, **when**, or **where** it's posted. The data does not support treating virality as something that can be engineered upfront through a content brief or posting schedule — but it does support a clear, actionable path: invest in creators with proven reach, build a fast-reaction system to amplify what's already working, and treat timing, category, and format as secondary optimizations layered on top.

This shifts the team's effort away from trying to predict winners in advance, and toward building the creator relationships and real-time responsiveness that the data shows actually drive results.